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FROM INDEPENDENCE TO DEMOCRACY (1948–2010)

Domestic events

British colonial rule ended in Burma on 4 January 1948[1] and the new country was based on the boundaries that pre-colonial Burma had briefly expanded to by 1824, as defined by the British colonial authorities in the mid-1930s when Burma was administratively separated from India. On independence, Burma was considered a rich country, with well-developed agriculture, major mineral reserves, and a well-educated population.[2] In particular, the British had expanded rice production in the lower Irrawaddy region (in part by bringing in Indian labourers) and this had led to Burma becoming one of the major producers in the world, providing the means to both feed the local population and to export to other, food hungry, states in the region.

On the other hand, the new state inherited a complex mixture of ethnic groups and religious beliefs, as regions populated by non-ethnic-Burman groups were included in the new country. Districts such as Shan, Kachin and Sagaing to the north and Chin to the west were all largely inhabited by non-Burman ethnic groups who were to face severe repression during the period after independence,[3] as were the Karen who lived both in the Irrawaddy Delta region and in what became Karen State to the east. The map at the beginning of this book shows the provincial boundaries of post-independence Burma including Arakan, renamed Rakhine.[4]

At its creation Burma also faced a significant internal debate among the new ruling elite. Some saw the new state as the means to create a Buddhist and Burman polity with other ethnicities and religious groups excluded. To them, this was overcoming the critical failure of British rule—that it had not